NAVIGATING SQL SERVER TO POSTGRESQL MIGRATION

And How DBAs Keep Their Sanity

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THE REALITY

NUMBERS

Modernize…

- Marketing vs Reality
- Database vs. Ecosystem
- Workload vs. Vague Scenarios
- Vanilla vs. Native
- Whole vs. Slice n' Dice

What are the numbers I've experienced?

THE WHY

WHY MIGRATE?

- SQL Server Enterprise licensing pressure
  - Cloud and AI modernization initiatives
  - Open-source ecosystem growth
  - AI project alignment
  - Someone thought it just sounded cool!

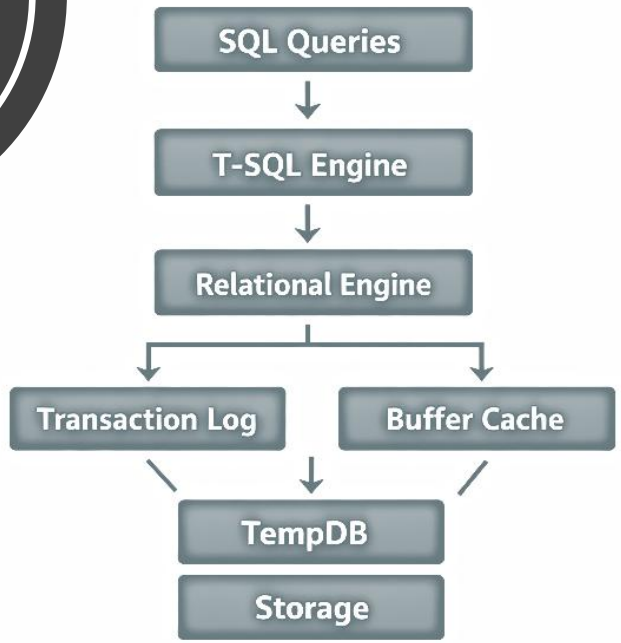
IT'S AN OPERATING MODEL SHIFT

Not just a platform change

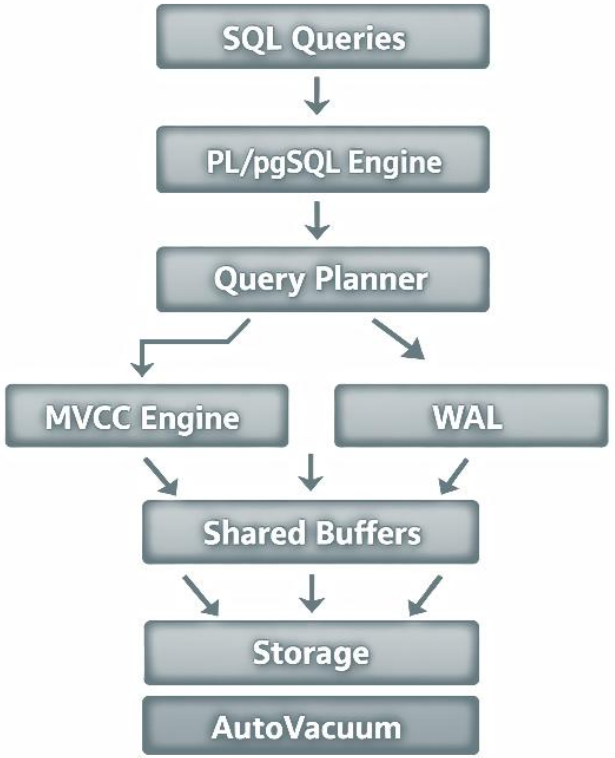
- DBA mindset, tooling, and governance must evolve
- Subtle assumptions can break in painful ways
- Migration is architectural, not syntactic

HIGH LEVEL

SQL Server Architecture



PostgreSQL Architecture



THE WHAT

CONCURRENCY MODEL DEEP DIVE

- SQL Server: Lock-based, TempDB heavy
  - PostgreSQL: MVCC, tuple versioning
  - Long transactions cause bloat in Postgres
  - It's not better, but just different…

VACUUM is mandatory for health

PROCEDURAL CODE & ECOSYSTEM GAPS

- SQL Agent → pg_cron or external schedulers
- SSIS →Airflow / ELT/ETL
- CLR → rewrite required
- Linked Servers → postgres_fdw

TYPES OF POSTGRES

- Native
- Compatible
- Cloud
- Serverless

POSTGRES VARIATIONS & CLOUD LOCK-IN

- Community vs RDS vs Aurora vs Azure vs AlloyDB
  - Extension differences/limitations
  - Superuser restrictions
  - Storage & HA differences

- Choose flavor depending on requirements
- Test on the actual platform
- Validate extensions needed are available
- Validate HA architecture
- Verify lock-in implications

STORAGE & INDEX ARCHITECTURE

SQL Server: Clustered index defines table

- Postgres: Heap + secondary indexes
- BRIN, GIN, GiST, SP-GIST, HASH index types
- Clustered strategy must be rethought

THERE'S AN EXTENSION FOR THAT

SQL Server has CLR integration and .NET assemblies inside the database, but…

Postgres has extensions

PostGIS
pgvector
pg_stat_activity

PL/Python, PL/Perl

Existing CLR-heavy workloads do require redesign, not just translation.

MIGRATION IS NOT SYNTAX TRANSLATION

- T-SQL ≠ PL/pgSQL
  - Optimizer differences
  - Concurrency model differences
  - Statistics & memory management differences
  - Process and data load changes

STATISTICS & PLAN STABILITY

- SQL Server: Query Store, plan forcing
  - Postgres: Statistics target tuning
  - Extended statistics optional
  - Plan governance must be rebuilt

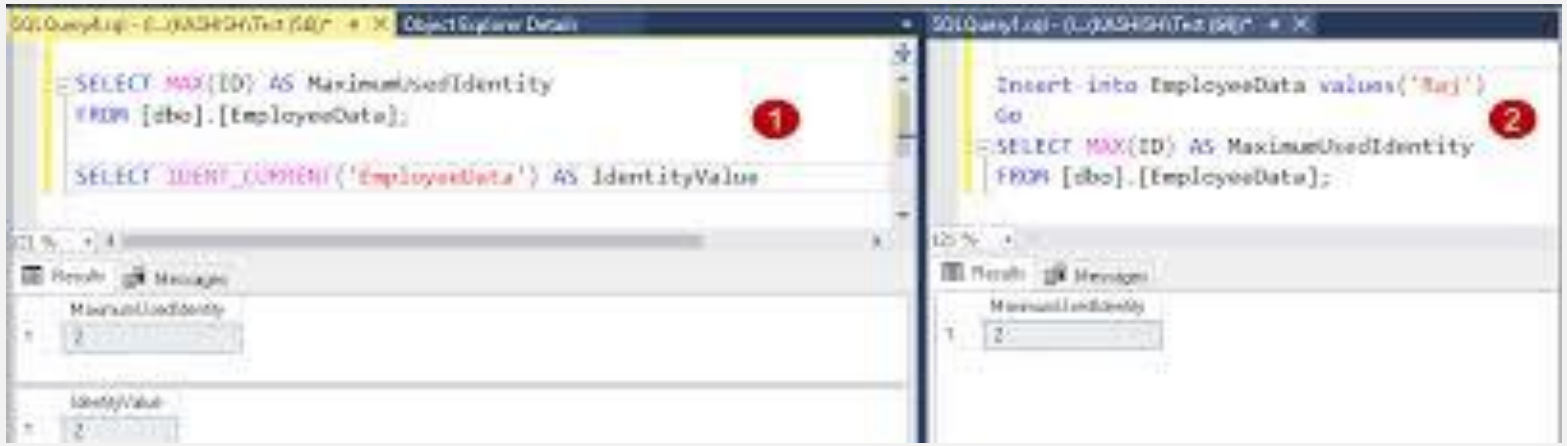
EXECUTION PLAN DIFFERENCES

- SQL Server: Memory grants, parameter sniffing
  - Postgres: work_mem sensitive, nested loop bias
  - Row estimation critical to performance
  - Plan stability requires new discipline

SCHEMA DIFFERENCES WITH DATA TYPES

UNIQUEIDENTIFIER → UUID

- DATETIME vs TIMESTAMP (timezone behavior)
- BIT vs BOOLEAN
- NVARCHAR vs TEXT/VARCHAR handling
- Implicit conversion behavior differences



IDENTITY COLUMNS AND SEQUENCES

IDENTITY vs GENERATED AS IDENTITY

- Sequence caching differences
- Gap behavior expectations
- Replication and failover considerations

ESCAPING LOCK-IN… INTO LOCK-IN

- Cloud-specific Architecture Pros/Cons
  - Managed service IOPS tiers
  - Superuser/OS-level lock-out
  - Automation of maintenance/backups
  - Different cloud versions often serve different purposes
  - Monitoring integration dependencies/restrictions
  - AI add-on billing layers

COST REDISTRIBUTION MODEL

- License removal ≠ total cost reduction
  - Cloud compute & IOPS
  - Scaling requirements after optimization loss
  - Read replicas & HA in multi-AZ environments
  - Ingress/egress charges/network enhancements
  - AI services & data pipelines
  - Application and code rewrites/refactoring
  - New Tooling licenses
  - Training

YOU DON’T REMOVE COST. YOU RELOCATE COST.

THE HOW

COMMON MIGRATION FAILURE POINTS

Underestimating query planner differences

- Ignoring autovacuum tuning
- Data type mismatches causing subtle bugs
- Lack of workload replay testing
- Declaring success without performance validation
- Defined cutover dates without understanding the nuances

VALIDATION AND PERFORMANCE

- Have a method to compare plan performance
  - Workload replay testing
  - Index usage analysis
  - Monitoring bloat and vacuum activity
  - Failover and HA testing WELL BEFORE cutover

PERFORMANCE VALIDATION FRAMEWORK

Inventory and classify workloads

- Baseline performance before migrations
- POC with production-like workload
- Consider parallel run validation

Replay real workloads

- Validate concurrency & failover
- Monitor vacuum & bloat
- Track plan regressions

Consider controlled and reversible cutover

AI USE CASE: STATIC CODE RISK SCORING

- Detect CLR & cross-database references
  - Flag transaction scope risks
  - Identify temp table heavy workloads
  - Generate object-level risk scores

AI USE CASE: QUERY PATTERN ANALYSIS

- Detect skewed predicates
  - Identify nested loop explosion risk
  - Highlight update churn tables
  - Predict MVCC bloat pressure

AI USE CASE: PLAN COMPARISON

- Compare SQL Server vs Postgres plans
  - Detect cardinality estimation drift
  - Highlight index differences
  - Flag regression risk before production

AUTOVACUUM & BLOAT RISKS

- Understand autovacuum thresholds
  - Monitor freeze age
  - Detect index bloat early
  - Cloud storage costs grow with bloat

MIGRATION TOOLS

HAVE TOOLS TO SUPPORT BOTH PLATFORMS

- Monitoring Visibility
- Migration for pipelines
- Automation for processes, transformations
- Clear communication with stakeholders
- Metric-driven validation

AI-ASSISTED MIGRATION RISK ANALYSIS

- Use AI to detect risk before migration
  - Analyze T-SQL complexity
  - Score rewrite effort
  - Flag architectural dependencies

RECOMMENDED MIGRATION FRAMEWORK

- Inventory & risk classification
  - AI-assisted analysis
  - Real-world POC testing
  - Parallel run & performance hardening

BEST DATABASE MIGRATION ASSISTANTS

- Pgloader with additional scripts
- AWS Transform for SQL Server Modernization
- Babelfish for Aurora PostgreSQL
- Ora2pg for SQL Server (with caveats)
- Azure SQL Server Migration Assistant (SSMA) for PostgreSQL
- Google Database Migration Service (DMS)
- SQLCMD and PSQL

DEMO

THE EASIEST MIGRATION

- Greenfield services
  - Cloud-native architecture
  - Avoid Enterprise core growth
  - AI-first data strategy

WHEN MIGRATION IS DANGEROUS

- Heavy CLR usage
  - Complex SSIS ecosystems
  - Tight latency SLAs
  - Vendor-locked applications

FINAL TAKEAWAYS

- Migration is architectural, not syntactic
  - Performance must be rebuilt and takes time
  - Cloud may reintroduce lock-in, so prepare decision makers
  - AI may reduce and ease some burden of migration

CLOSING THOUGHT

Escaping licensing does not eliminate engineering responsibility.

- Success requires discipline, measurement, automation, and governance.

Costs are often shifted from database licensing to cloud and AI.

Having tools that cover both platforms can make the difference.

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THANK YOU!

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